

PRODUCT THINKING CASE STUDY

Designing Consent for Kids

A DPDP-first approach to teen accounts on VuePlay
(case study modeled on YouTube's teen-account experience)

Vedantu · Product Management Internship
Aishwary Singh Rathour



Video platforms weren't built for DPDP's rules on kids

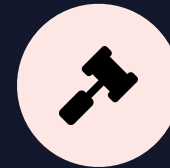
Product & focus: VuePlay (case study modeled on YouTube) — How the product handles data and consent for 13–17 year old accounts.

Why it matters

- **User trust** Teens and parents leave or never sign up when data practices feel invasive or opaque.
- **Legal exposure** Section 9 non-compliance carries penalties up to ₹200 crore under the DPDP Schedule.
- **Child wellbeing** Behavioural profiling of minors is now explicitly prohibited, not just discouraged.

Assumptions made explicit

- Tens of millions of self-declared teen accounts exist in India today
- Date-of-birth is self-reported once at signup and rarely re-verified
- No verifiable parental consent flow exists in the current product



₹200 Cr

maximum penalty for non-compliance with children's data provisions under the DPDP Act's schedule

Scope for this deck

Teen consent, verification & profiling — not the full data/privacy surface of the product.

Two people are affected by every consent decision



The Teen Viewer

13–17 years old

Uses the app daily to watch, learn, and unwind often on a shared or hand-me-down phone.

Pain points today

- Doesn't read consent text, just wants to get to the video
- Has no idea their watch history builds an ad profile
- Wants privacy without extra friction



The Parent / Guardian

Owens the DPDP-required consent

Isn't in the app day-to-day, but is legally the one who must consent on the child's behalf.

Pain points today

- Rarely knows what data is actually being collected
- Has no easy way to review or withdraw consent later
- Distrusts anything that feels like a formality, not a real choice

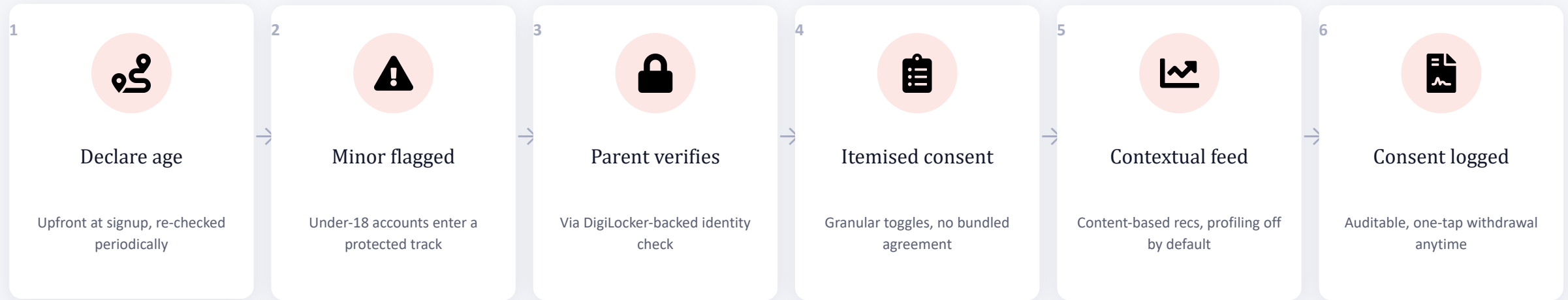
Where today's flow falls short of DPDP

Today (assumed)

DPDP requires

Age check	Self-declared once at signup, never re-verified	Ongoing, verifiable age assurance
Ads & recommendations	Behavioural profiling drives ranking and ad targeting	Prohibited for minors DPDP Section 9(3)
Consent	One bundled “I agree” checkbox	Itemised, granular, affirmative Section 6
Withdrawing consent	Buried several taps deep in settings	As easy as giving it Section 6(4)

A verified, itemised, reversible consent flow



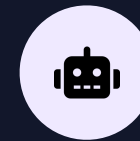
Why this, not the alternatives

Rejected — blanket age-gate everyone under 18:

technically simple, but kills engagement for a huge, legitimate user segment.

Rejected — leave the status quo:

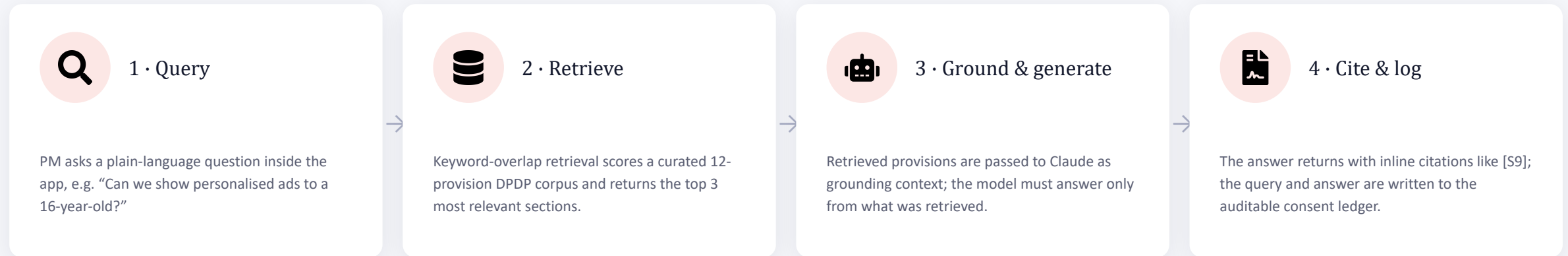
non-compliant, and exposes the business to Section 9 penalties.



Built as a working prototype: a content-based (non-behavioural) recommendation engine, plus a RAG compliance copilot that checks decisions against the Act.

A compliance copilot

The prototype includes a retrieval-augmented (RAG) assistant that lets a PM check any feature decision against the DPDP Act before shipping — grounded in real provisions, with inline citations.



EXAMPLE — LIVE IN THE PROTOTYPE

Q: “Can we show personalised ads to a 16-year-old?”

A: No. [S9(3)] explicitly prohibits behavioural tracking and targeted advertising directed at children. Recommendation: disable profiling and ads for this account, use content-based ranking instead.



Built with real engineering trade-offs

Retrieval is keyword-based (a static front-end can't run FAISS). If the live Claude API is unreachable after deployment, it falls back to composing an answer from the same retrieved provisions — same reasoning pattern I used for LexGraph's citation-backed retrieval.

How we'd know this is actually working



NORTH STAR

Share of active teen accounts with
a valid, current verified parental
consent

Target: 90%+ within 60 days of launch

Supporting metrics

- Consent completion rate (started → granted)
- Median time to consent
- Parental verification drop-off rate

Guardrail metrics

- Teen DAU / engagement (must not collapse)
- Support ticket volume tied to consent flow

Success criteria

- 90%+ valid consent within 60 days of launch
- <15% drop in teen engagement post-launch
- 100% of breaches reported within the 72-hour window

If guardrails break, we pause and fix the North Star doesn't override engagement collapsing.

North Star drops 15% in week 3



Instrumentation bug

Logging or event-tracking change silently mis-counts valid consent



Verification outage

DigiLocker (or equivalent) API degraded, blocking parent verification



UX regression

A dependency or config change broke a step in the consent flow



Policy change

A rule update shifts what counts as “valid” consent



Cohort effect

A new user cohort (region, platform) with different consent behaviour

Data I'd pull

- Consent funnel drop-off by step, day, and cohort
- Verification-partner error/latency logs
- Release & config change log for the window

Root-cause approach

- Segment the drop by platform, geography, device
- Compare against control cohorts unaffected by any suspected cause
- Rule in/out fastest-to-check hypotheses first

Next steps

- Hotfix if it's instrumentation or UX
- Escalate to the verification partner if it's an outage
- Communicate proactively if it's a policy shift

Monitoring consent health at a glance (mock data)

87%

Valid consent rate

71%

Teen DAU retained

4.2 min

Median time to consent

Main KPI

Valid Consent Rate

Trend valid consent rate, last 8 weeks

Segmentation by age band

Phased launch



Phase 1 Pilot

One state, one platform (Android). Validate the verification partner integration and consent-completion rate before scaling.



Phase 2 Expand

Roll out nationally, by cohort. Watch guardrail metrics closely; pause expansion if engagement drops beyond threshold.



Phase 3 Full rollout

100% of self-declared teen accounts. Consent ledger and dashboard fully live for ongoing monitoring.



What we CAN'T A/B test

The core requirement — verified parental consent before processing a minor's data — is a legal mandate, not a growth experiment. It ships to 100% of eligible accounts.



What we CAN test

The UX around it: notice copy, step order, verification method framing, and reminder timing for incomplete consent — all fair game for experimentation.

What we're accepting, going in



Engineering complexity

New identity-verification integration, plus a parallel non-profiling recommendation path to build and maintain.



Business impact

Added consent steps will cost some conversion; targeted-ad revenue from the teen segment drops to zero.



User impact

Real friction for legitimate users, especially where a parent is hard to reach for verification.



Edge cases

Declined consent, no parent available, mid-flow age changes, and deletion requests need explicit handling.



Trade-offs accepted

We chose compliance and trust over short-term engagement and ad revenue from this segment.

Net bet

Trust, once lost with parents and regulators, is far more expensive to rebuild than the ad revenue we're giving up.